Grease the groove: your first two weeks

Mission: 20 strict pull-ups, non-stop. Today: 8.

> **Today's win:** do your first *groove set* of 4 strict pull-ups, then log it. That's the whole plan in miniature.

The idea in one breath

Pull-ups get better when you practise them **often** and **fresh**, not when you grind them to exhaustion. Pavel Tsatsouline calls this "greasing the groove": many sub-maximal sets spread through the day, never to failure, so you're "training as often as possible while being as fresh as possible."[1] Small sets need little recovery, which is why you can repeat them many times a day.[2] In Pavel's article, a 60-year-old who did chin-ups every time he went to the basement went on to do 20.[1]

That fits you well: each set takes about 30 seconds, and you don't have to change clothes for it.

Your two-week plan

Day	What
Mon–Fri	**Groove sets**: 4 strict reps (half your max of 8). Do 4–6 sets, at least an hour apart. Daily total: 16–24 reps.
Sat	Optional: 2–3 groove sets if you feel fresh. Otherwise rest.
Sun	Rest. Armstrong's program also takes two days off from pull-ups each week.[3]
Week 2	If week 1 felt easy, go to 6 sets a day, or do 5 reps on your first two sets.
Wed Oct 28	**Test**: warm up with 2 easy reps, rest 3 minutes, then do one strict max set. Skip groove sets that day.

Rules for a groove set

- Strict form: start from a dead hang, get your chin over the bar, and don't kip. Armstrong says quality matters more than numbers.[3]
- Stop each set while every rep still moves at the same speed. If a rep slows down, the set was too big.
- Stay well away from failure. Pavel warns that going to exhaustion burns you out.[1]
- If your elbows or shoulders hurt, take 2 days off and then go back to smaller sets.
- Missed a day? Don't make it up. Just do the next day as planned.

Why there's a test: one trainee found GTG alone stalled him, and regular max tests plus harder days helped him break through.[4] Lesson 2 will add Armstrong-style structure after your Oct 28 test.

Log today

Text Gopher your sets and reps each day. They get added to the progress log.

Check yourself

1. Your max is 8. How big is one groove set?

- 6 reps
- 4 reps
- 8 reps

2. When does a groove set end?

- well before any struggle
- at first failed rep
- after last slow rep

3. How far apart should groove sets be?

- five minutes apart
- fifteen minutes apart
- about an hour apart

4. Your elbow aches midweek. What do you do?

- push through the ache
- rest it, then reduce
- add more daily sets

Read this

Primary source: The Armstrong Pull-up Program, a two-page PDF from the USMC written for exactly your goal of 20 reps. Read it now, because it's what you'll follow after week 2. Background: Pavel's original GTG article.

> Anything unclear? Want the sets moved around your workday? **Ask your teacher.** Just message me in chat. Text me your daily totals, and send your test number on Oct 28.

Sources: [1] Tsatsouline, "Grease the Groove for Strength" (reprint). [2] Fitness Stack Exchange Q&A 3448. [3] Armstrong Pull-up Program, USMC OSO PDF. [4] r/bodyweightfitness, "My Long Journey to 20 Pullups."